

8.1 The Toolbox

We're assuming that you've read §5.1 and made sure that your PC is up to the task—especially if you're going to be mixing music in real-time. The next thing, of course, is software. To choose the right software, you'll first need to decide how you're going to produce your music. Would you rather mix tracks live for a party at home (karaoke night, perhaps?), or would you rather create your mix at your pace? We've looked at software in both categories, so take your pick!

To our considerable disappointment, we've discovered that though there are some good free tools, none of them really holds a candle to the paid, more advanced versions. No “free vs. paid” war here—paid wins each time.

VirtualDJ—The Life of the Party

The darling of many professional DJs across the world, VirtualDJ is so easy to use you probably wouldn't believe that even the pros use it. It's got a typical two-turntable setup—load your files onto them and mix away! You can even scratch



VirtualDJ—quite like the real DJ's set up

records back and forth for some cool intro and exit effects. And with its special “beatlock” engine, your tracks will emerge from a scratch still in sync. You will also have a number of sound bites and effects which you can work into your mix. For karaoke night, there's a special effect that lets you cut out vocals (though the accuracy of this feature can't always be guaranteed) so you can sing along without the real singer's voice bothering you. You can record your session as an